TALK FOUR

4 To This End Was I Born

"To this end was I born, and for this cause came I into the world, that I should bear witness unto the truth."

JOHN 18:37 · ABOUT 10 MINUTES

On the last morning of His life, Jesus stood before the Roman governor. Pilate asked Him, "Art thou a king then?" Jesus answered, "To this end was I born, and for this cause came I into the world, that I should bear witness unto the truth." Most people my age are still trying to decide what to do with their lives. Standing before the man who could sentence Him to death, Jesus knew He had accomplished the reason He had been born.

His work had been given to Him before the world was made. Peter writes that Christ "verily was foreordained before the foundation of the world." The Lord told Moses that the Son was "my Beloved and Chosen from the beginning." Christ Himself told the brother of Jared, "I am he who was prepared from the foundation of the world to redeem my people." Foreordination means being chosen and prepared for a work before coming to earth. But Jesus still had to come here and do what He had agreed to do. His life helps us understand what a promise made before birth might mean for us.

The Lord showed Abraham "the intelligences that were organized before the world was," including "many of the noble and great ones." Of these, the Lord said, "These I will make my rulers." Then He told Abraham, "Thou art one of them; thou wast chosen before thou wast born." Abraham was learning something about himself that the Lord had known all along.

The Prophet Jeremiah learned something similar when the Lord called him to be a prophet. He lived in Jerusalem about six hundred years before Christ, during the same years Lehi lived there. Some of Jeremiah's prophecies were on the plates of brass, and Nephi mentions his imprisonment. Many of us

know his words from a newer translation: “For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, plans to give you hope and a future.” Long before Jeremiah wrote those words, the Lord told him about the purpose of his own life: “Before I formed thee in the belly I knew thee,” said the Lord, “and before thou camest forth out of the womb I sanctified thee, and I ordained thee a prophet unto the nations.” Jeremiah did not feel ready. He answered, “Behold, I cannot speak: for I am a child.”

Alma explains that preparation for these callings began with choices. The priests of God were “called and prepared from the foundation of the world” because of “their exceeding faith and good works.” In the first place, they were “left to choose good or evil.” They had agency before coming here, and they used it well. Alma says that others “might have had as great privilege as their brethren” and that “in the first place they were on the same standing with their brethren.” These callings came with preparation and responsibility. The choices people made before this life mattered, just as our choices matter now.

Brother Hammon has taught us to distinguish foreordination from predestination, or the idea that our future has already been decided for us. Being foreordained does not mean we have no choice about what happens next. We made a promise using our agency, and we still have to use our agency to keep it. John Taylor said that “the making of a covenant naturally implies two parties” and that “if the people fulfil their covenant, the Lord is bound to fulfil his.” A covenant made before this life can still be kept or broken here.

The Lord told Abraham, “We will prove them herewith, to see if they will do all things whatsoever the Lord their God shall command them.” We have come here to choose, even though we cannot remember the promises we made. I think there is something important in that. We have to learn to love what is right and choose it without a memory of standing before God and saying we would.

Jeremiah’s life shows how hard keeping a calling can be. For years he warned Jerusalem of its coming destruction, and the people did not want to hear him. A priest named Pashur had him beaten and put in the stocks. Later,

Jeremiah was lowered into a dungeon where he sank in the mud. At one point, he decided he would stop speaking for the Lord: "I will not make mention of him, nor speak any more in his name." But remaining silent brought its own pain. "His word was in mine heart as a burning fire shut up in my bones." Jeremiah had been chosen before he was born, and he could not stop from keeping his covenants. He had to live the calling the Lord had given him.

The disciples once asked Jesus a question. Seeing a man who had been blind from birth, they asked, "Master, who did sin, this man, or his parents, that he was born blind?" Their question implies that they thought the man could have done something before birth to account for his blindness. Jesus corrected their attempt to assign blame: "Neither hath this man sinned, nor his parents: but that the works of God should be made manifest in him." Where the disciples were looking for someone's wrongdoing, Jesus saw an opportunity for God's work, and He healed the man.

Our understanding of preparation before birth also includes agreements about the lives we would enter—the family we would join, the time we would live, and, for many of us, the person we would marry. Mosiah Hancock, whose father was a bodyguard to the Prophet Joseph Smith, recorded a vision of the pre-existence. His account is not scripture, but it gives a personal picture of this preparation. In the vision, he asks who will go to earth and be his father. A man named Levi steps forward, and a woman says, "I will go down and be your mother." The family he knew on earth had a history that began in the presence of the Lord.

Christ spoke of His life as the fulfillment of a purpose He had already accepted. "I came down from heaven," He said, "not to do mine own will, but the will of him that sent me." More than once, John records that no one could lay hands on Jesus "because his hour was not yet come." Then, on the night before His death, Jesus prayed, "Father, the hour is come." He could say to the Father, "I have finished the work which thou gavest me to do." He had spent His life doing that work, and He would remain faithful through what lay ahead. When Jesus stood before Pilate the next morning, His answer came from a purpose He had lived.

I think this matters in our everyday lives, even if we do not know much about what we were called to do. We know this much: we have a calling in the gospel. We have people to care for and responsibilities to perform. Remembering that I agreed to come to my family can change how I respond when we are having a hard time together. I can ask what I came to do for them and what I still need to learn.

The Prophet Jeremiah wrote his words about the Lord's plans to people who had been carried captive to Babylon. They were far from home and could not see how their lives would turn out. In the King James translation, the promise reads, "For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, saith the Lord, thoughts of peace, and not of evil, to give you an expected end." The Lord does not forget us, and He intends good things for us.

We may not remember what we promised before we were born. Jesus knew what He had come to do, and He finished it. I believe He knows what each of us came here to do, too. We can begin with what He has already asked of us. This will help us do what we came here to do.

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The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.